Who Wants to Be a Criminologist? (Group 6): Speaker Script

MCCJ 527 | 10-minute group presentation | 6 members × 2 slides × ~50 seconds each

Tips: *Text in [square brackets] is a stage cue, not something to say aloud. Each slide is about 110–130 words, roughly 50 seconds at a calm pace. Practise once with a timer.*

MEMBER 1 – Roll 27 – [Your Name]

Slide 1: Round 1 question: the real contract value (about 50 seconds)

[Big game-show energy.] Good morning, and welcome to… Who Wants to Be a Criminologist? The War Dogs edition! We are Group 6, and today you are the contestants.

Here are the rules: we ask a question, you vote by raising your hand for A, B, C or D, and then we reveal the answer, and the criminology behind it. Six rounds. Let's play.

Round one, for 100 points. *[Read the question.]* War Dogs, from 2016, is based on a true story. How much was the real Pentagon contract that the company AEY won?

[Point to each option.] Hands up for A, 3 million… B, 29.8 million… C, 298 million… D, 2.98 billion? *[Count hands, react.]* Let's see the answer!

Slide 2: Round 1 answer: the film in three acts (about 50 seconds)

The answer is C: 298 million dollars! *[React to the votes.]* A real contract, signed in 2007, to arm the Afghan National Army.

Here is the film in brief. It was directed by Todd Phillips and stars Jonah Hill and Miles Teller.

Act One: David, a broke massage therapist, joins his friend Efraim's company AEY, bidding online for small military contracts, and pushes a stuck shipment through Jordan into Iraq.

Act Two: a watch-listed broker, Henry, gives them access to old ammunition in Albania, and they win the Afghan contract.

Act Three: the ammunition is Chinese-made and banned, so they hide it. Efraim gets four years in prison, David seven months of house arrest.

Our thesis: organized crime doesn't always carry guns. Sometimes it sells them. [Member 2], round two!

MEMBER 2 – Roll 8 – [Your Name]

Slide 3: Round 2 question: is AEY organized crime? (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 1]! Round two, for 200 points. Now it gets harder.

[Read the question.] Under the UN Convention against Transnational Organized Crime, is AEY an "organized criminal group"?

A: No, because it was a legally registered company.

B: No, because it had fewer than three people.

C: Yes, because it had three or more people, existing over time, committing serious crime for profit.

D: Only if it used violence.

[Count hands.] Interesting! Many people think organized crime must mean violence, or the mafia. Let's find out.

Slide 4: Round 2 answer: UNTOC vs Abadinsky (about 50 seconds)

The answer is C! Under Article 2 of the UN Convention, an organized criminal group is a structured group of three or more people, existing for a period of time, committing serious crime for material benefit. AEY ticks every box: Efraim, David, their financier, Henry and the suppliers, operating for years, committing fraud for millions.

[Red card.] But here is the twist. Abadinsky's classic attributes describe the mafia: hierarchy, exclusive membership, rituals, and survival after arrests. AEY has none of them.

So our classification: organized white-collar crime. A legal company, committing organized and transnational fraud across five countries.

[Member 3], round three!

MEMBER 3 – Roll 37 – [Your Name]

Slide 5: Round 3 question: which model fits? (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 2]! Round three, for 300 points. This one is about the models we studied in class.

[Read the question.] AEY started as a legal business and slid into fraud as demand grew. Which model of organized crime fits best?

A: the hierarchical model of Cressey.

B: the patron–client model of Albini.

C: the enterprise model of Smith.

D: the traditional mafia family.

[Count hands.] Hint: think about the word "slid". Let's reveal it.

Slide 6: Round 3 answer: enterprise and network models (about 50 seconds)

The answer is C: Smith's enterprise model! Smith argued that legal and illegal businesses sit on one spectrum and respond to the same market demand. That is exactly AEY: it moved from legal bidding, to grey deals with fixers, to outright fraud.

The network model of Morselli also fits strongly. Power belonged to brokers who connected separate worlds: AEY linked the Pentagon to Henry, and Henry linked them to Albania.

Albini's patron–client model fits partly: Henry trades access for a share of profits.

But Cressey's hierarchical model, the mafia model, fits poorly. There were no ranks, no code and no family.

[Member 4], round four!

MEMBER 4 – Roll 33 – [Your Name]

Slide 7: Round 4 question: Klitgaard's formula (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 3]! Round four, for 500 points. Let's talk about corruption.

[Read the question.] Robert Klitgaard has a famous formula: corruption equals M plus D minus A. What do M, D and A stand for?

A: Money plus Drugs minus Arrests.

B: Mafia plus Deals minus Audits.

C: Monopoly plus Discretion minus Accountability.

D: Motive plus Desire minus Anxiety.

[Count hands.] Some of these sound very tempting! Let's see.

Slide 8: Round 4 answer: corruption and state-corporate crime (about 50 seconds)

The answer is C: Monopoly plus Discretion minus Accountability!

Let's apply it to the film. Monopoly: Henry controls the only access to cheap Balkan ammunition, so everyone must pay him. Discretion: officials, fixers and border agents decide with little scrutiny, and middlemen skim money. And accountability is low: in the rush of war, a company run by a man in his early twenties passes the Pentagon's vetting.

Transparency International defines corruption as the abuse of entrusted power for private gain. And this is also state-corporate crime: the harm grew out of a government policy of outsourcing war to the lowest bidder.

[Member 5], round five!

MEMBER 5 – Roll 24 – [Your Name]

Slide 9: Round 5 question: neutralization (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 4]! Round five, for 1,000 points. We are getting close to the end.

[Read the question in the character's voice.] "The troops still get bullets that work. Who is harmed?" This kind of excuse is an example of which technique of neutralization?

A: Denial of injury.

B: Denial of the victim.

C: Condemnation of the condemners.

D: Appeal to higher loyalties.

[Count hands.] Careful, A and B sound very similar! Let's reveal it.

Slide 10: Round 5 answer: why they did it (about 50 seconds)

The answer is A: denial of injury! The offender claims that no one is really hurt. Denial of the victim would mean "the victim deserved it", which is different.

Sykes and Matza showed that offenders know the rules, but use excuses to switch them off. In the film, the characters also condemn the condemners, "the government does it too", and appeal to higher loyalties, "I did it for my family". These are our paraphrases, not exact lines.

Three more theories explain their choices. Strain theory: David is broke with a baby coming, so he innovates. Differential association: he learns fraud from Efraim. And rational choice: a huge reward, a small chance of getting caught.

[Member 6], the final round!

MEMBER 6 – Roll 21 – [Your Name]

Slide 11: Final round question: how accurate is the film? (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 5]! And now... the final round. For one million points! *[Pause for effect.]*

[Read the question slowly.] How accurately does War Dogs portray organized crime and corruption?

A: Completely accurate, like a documentary.

B: Accurate in substance, but exaggerated in style.

C: Pure fiction, with no basis in fact.

D: It makes the fraud look worse than it really was.

[Count hands.] Is that your final answer? Let's lock it in.

Slide 12: Final round answer: verdict and conclusion (about 50 seconds)

The answer is B: accurate in substance, exaggerated in style!

[Green card.] What the film gets right: it breaks the mafia stereotype, it fits the UN definition and the enterprise and network models, and the contract, the repackaging and the sentences are all real.

[Red card.] What it gets wrong: the comedy glamorizes fraud, Henry is a composite character, the threats in Albania were invented, and it ignores real victims, like the 26 people killed in the Gërdec depot explosion in 2008.

Our conclusion: AEY is organized crime under the UN definition, but not the mafia. And the lesson for Bangladesh: big procurement relies on middlemen too, so vetting contractors is crime prevention.

Thank you for playing! Every contestant wins today. We're happy to take your questions.